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Interesting Statistics and Info Regarding Harvard Admissions (NOT Regarding Affirmative Action)

Best of A2C

If you prefer watching instead of reading, check out my video where I go over this info! :)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3OlBFz_vtS0

First, a breakdown of how Harvard's 4 main factors are assessed on a scale of 1-6 (1 being the best):

Academic Rating (0.5% of applicants get a 1, 42.3% of applicants get a 2):

1. Summa potential. Genuine scholar; near-perfect scores and grades (in most cases) combined with unusual creativity and possible evidence of original scholarship.
2. Magna potential: Excellent student with superb grades and mid-to-high-700 scores (33+ ACT).

3. Cum laude potential: Very good student with excellent grades and mid-600 to low-700 scores (29 to 32 ACT).
4. Adequate preparation. Respectable grades and low-to-mid-600 scores (26 to 29) ACT).
5. Marginal potential. Modest grades and 500 scores (25 and below ACT).
6. Achievement or motivation marginal or worse.

Difference between 1 and 2: You need to show academic excellence outside of just your grades and test scores in order to get a 1, most often through very prestigious academic competitions/awards and/or published research with a professor.

Extracurricular Rating (0.3% of applicants get a 1, 23.8% of applicants get a 2):

1. Unusual strength in one or more areas. Possible national-level achievement or professional experience. A potential major contributor at Harvard. Truly unusual achievement.
2. Strong secondary school contribution in one or more areas such as class president, newspaper editor, etc. Local or regional recognition; major accomplishment(s). [in another filing]: "Significant school, and possibly regional accomplishments: for example, an applicant who was the student body president or captain of the debate team and the leader of multiple additional clubs."
3. Solid participation but without special distinction. (Upgrade 3+ to 2- in some cases if the e/c is particularly extensive and substantive.)
4. Little or no participation.
5. Substantial activity outside of conventional EC participation such as family commitments or term-time work (could be included with other e/c to boost the rating or left as a "5" if it is more representative of the student's commitment).
6. Special circumstances limit or prevent participation (e.g. a physical condition).

Difference between 1 and 2: You have to achieve at a national/professional level in your activities in order to get a 1, simply being elite at a school or state level will not get you over a 2 in this category.

Athletic Rating (0.9% of applicants get a 1, 9.2% of applicants get a 2):

1. Unusually strong prospect for varsity sports at Harvard, desired by Harvard coaches.
2. Strong secondary school contribution in one or more areas; possible leadership role(s).
3. Active participation.
4. Little or no interest.
5. Substantial activity outside of conventional EC participation such as family commitments or term-time work (could be included with other e/c to boost the rating or left as a "5" if it is more representative of the student's commitment).
6. Physical condition prevents significant activity.

Difference between 1 and 2: Being recruited for a sport will get you a 1 here, but you can still help out your case a lot by being a strong non-recruited high school athlete and qualifying for a 2.

Personal Rating (0.0% of applicants -- or below 50 total every year -- get a 1, 20.8% of applicants get a 2):

1. Outstanding
2. Very Strong
3. Generally Positive
4. Bland or somewhat negative or immature
5. Questionable personal qualities
6. Worrisome personal qualities

Difference between 1 and 2: Way too vague to tell for sure, but some traits I often heard from Harvard alumni interviewers for students that received a 1 are "seemed like they would be amazing friends for their classmates", "didn't appear to treat college like a competition for grades", "wouldn't be intimidated by other bright and active people", and "memorable even 20-30 years later." Essentially, **you must stand out as a person everyone wants to be around (which is highly subjective)**... how you do that is really a unique thing for everyone

Chances of admission to Harvard based on these ratings:

Candidates who Excel in One Dimension:

1. Academic rating of 1, no other 1s: 68% admission rate
2. Extracurricular rating of 1, no other 1s: 48% admission rate
3. Personal rating of 1, no other 1s: 66% admission rate
4. Athletic rating of 1, no other 1s: 88% admission rate

Multi-Dimensional (or "well-rounded") Candidates:

1. Three ratings of 2, one rating of 3 or 4: 43% admission rate
2. Four ratings of 2: 68% admission rate

Weaker Candidates:

1. No ratings of 1 or 2: 0.1% admission rate

Main Take-aways from this information (TL;DR):

1. Achieving a 1 in any category is obviously extremely difficult (less than 1% of applicants get a 1 for each factor), but will give you an **enormous boost** in admissions if you are able to obtain one

2. Being "well-rounded" to a point where Harvard truly cares is arguably even harder than achieving a 1 in one category -- those who are considered "multi-dimensional" by Harvard are still outstanding in almost every, if not every, area and are **still excelling** over the vast majority of their peers in **each regard** -- attempting to spread yourself so thin among so many aspects in high school will almost certainly be **draining**
3. Every factor appears to be about equal in importance (athletic rating becomes *comparatively* less important after a rating of 1, extracurricular rating becomes *comparatively* more important after a rating of 1)
4. If you are truly invested in getting into Harvard (or any other Ivy League), your best bet is probably to find an academic area, extracurricular activity, or sport that you **actually have a passion** for (not something you are doing just so it "looks good on apps") and try to become elite in that area at a **national and/or distinct level** -- pull this off and you are more than half-way on the way to acceptance
5. Although this information does help paint a clearer picture of how good you have to be to get in, the admissions process is still hugely confusing and it is hugely impressive how much those who are admitted into these schools have to achieve in order to get in